

PRANAYAMA

Yogis use *pranayama* or breathwork to control their *prana* and anchor to the present moment. The word *prana* in Sanskrit means vital energy or life-force energy that permeates through us and everything. Interestingly, *prana* simultaneously means breath. Yogis believe that you can change the flow and qualities of your energetics by breath control.

INHALE AND EXHALE

When you inhale, blood is shunted to your heart and lungs to help them function. Baroreceptors (see p.134) sense this increased pressure and respond by signaling to let off the brake pedal, momentarily increasing sympathetic activity. During each exhale, your heart is slightly more relaxed with increased parasympathetic activity. This explains why elongating your exhales in *pranayama* is relaxing.

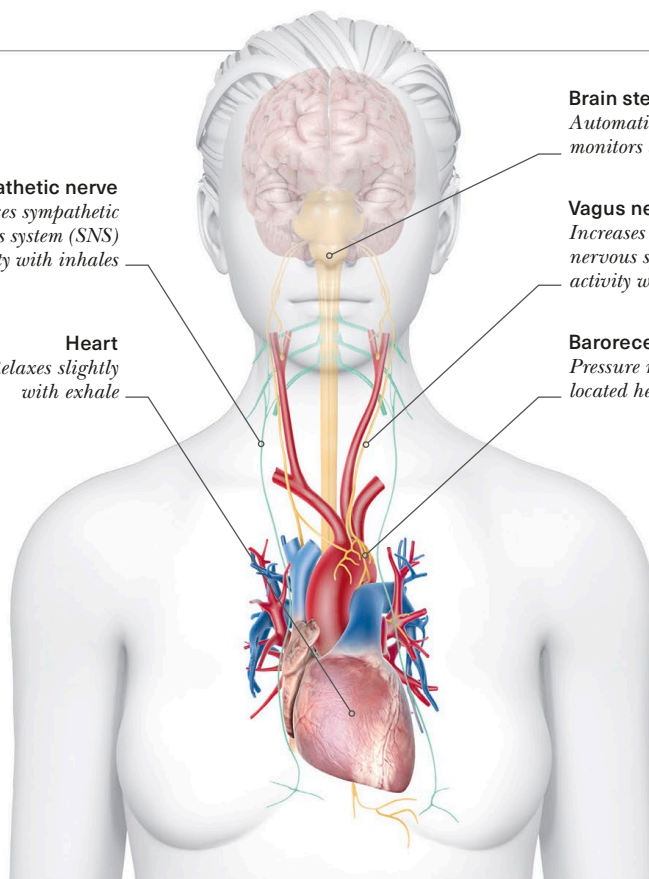
Sympathetic nerve
Increases sympathetic nervous system (SNS) activity with inhales

Heart
Relaxes slightly with exhale

Brain stem
Automatically monitors breathing

Vagus nerve
Increases parasympathetic nervous system (PSNS) activity with exhales

Baroreceptor
Pressure receptors located here



BREATHWORK PRACTICES

Modern yogis use breathwork for health benefits, including overcoming inefficient breathing patterns from a culture of poor posture and stress. Through altering your breath, you change your state of mind. For example, you may practice left nostril breathing and bee breath to calm down or right nostril breathing and *kapalabhati* for alertness.

BREATH OF FIRE (KAPALABHATI)

This is a fast breath that mimics hyperventilation, increasing your heart rate and blood pressure. It also tones your abdominals. Avoid this technique if you are pregnant or have anxiety, certain eye conditions, or high blood pressure. Similar effects and precautions apply for holding your breath (*kumbhaka*).

